

6 > Find your niche and ideal listener

- **Step 2:** List subjects you could happily discuss for the next year without getting bored.
- **Step 3:** List problems, questions or curiosities people regularly have around those subjects.

Look for overlaps. You may love smartphones and know them professionally, but “smartphones” remains broad. If people often ask which phone to buy on a budget, a stronger proposition might be “smartphone buying advice for value-conscious Indian consumers”.

Define the listener before the show

Many beginners imagine “everyone” as their audience. That makes planning harder, not easier. A useful podcast is made for a specific listener, even if others eventually discover it.

Create a one-page listener persona. Focus only on information that affects the show:

- Approximate age or life stage
- Profession or area of interest
- Existing knowledge of your subject
- Problems they want solved
- Content they already consume
- Preferred language or language mix
- When and where they might listen
- Why they would return

Imagine a 24-year-old first-job professional in Bengaluru who understands basic investing but is confused by mutual funds, taxes and insurance. She listens during her commute and prefers clear English with occasional Hindi phrases. That profile suggests that 20-minute practical episodes may work better than two-hour conversations loaded with jargon.

Study the competition

Competition is evidence that an audience exists. Your task is not to find a subject nobody has covered. It is to serve listeners in a more useful or distinctive way.

- **Step 1:** Search Spotify, YouTube, Apple Podcasts and Google using your proposed topic.
- **Step 2:** Select five to ten relevant Indian and international shows.
- **Step 3:** Note their episode length, publishing frequency, host style, popular topics, titles and guest mix.
- **Step 4:** Read comments and reviews. Look for repeated complaints, questions or requests.
- **Step 5:** Identify what is missing. Existing shows may be too advanced, too celebrity-driven, too long, too US-centric, or unavailable in an Indian language.

Create a comparison table with columns for show name, target audience, format, strength, weakness and opportunity. Your niche often becomes clearer once you see what everybody else is doing.

CREATE A 25-EPIISODE STRESS TEST

A niche that sounds exciting but produces only six good ideas is not ready.

Set a timer for 30 minutes and write 25 possible episode titles. Divide them into beginner questions, advanced topics, interviews, mistakes, case studies, comparisons and timely subjects.

If you struggle before reaching 25, the niche may be too narrow. If you generate 100 unrelated topics, it may be too broad. Circle the ten strongest ideas; these can form your first season.

Before moving on, complete four things: a one-paragraph listener persona, a five-show competitor audit, a one-sentence listener promise and a list of 25 episode ideas.

That combination is more valuable than an expensive microphone. Equipment can improve sound. A clearly defined niche gives people a reason to press play.

Write a one sentence listener promise

Your show should be explainable in one sentence. Use this formula:

“This podcast helps [specific listener] achieve [specific outcome] through [type of content].”

For example: “This podcast helps first-time Indian founders understand practical business finance through short conversations with operators and experts.”

Avoid vague promises such as “interesting conversations with interesting people”. They describe thousands of podcasts.

Test your sentence. Would the intended listener immediately know the show is for them? Does it suggest what future episodes might cover? Could someone recommend it easily? If not, rewrite it.

Test the idea before recording

Before buying equipment or producing a full season, test the proposition with real people.

Find five to ten people resembling your intended listener. Send them your one-sentence promise and five sample episode titles. Ask which episodes they would actually play, what questions remain unanswered and what would make the show worth following.

Do not ask, “Do you like my podcast idea?” Polite people often say yes. Ask behavioural questions: “Which title would you click first?” “What do you already listen to on this subject?” “What is missing?”

Use the answers to refine your scope. 